LLMs are not Tools, LLMs are Maybe-Tools

Why the Category You Were Sold Is Not the Category You Received

Registry: [HOWL-INFO-8-2026]

Series Path: [HOWL-INFO-1-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-2-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-3-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-4-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-5-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-6-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-7-2026] → [HOWL-INFO-8-2026]

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Abstract

Current large language model products are marketed as tools and delivered as something else. The something else is a system that sometimes produces tool-like output and sometimes deploys interference behaviors — refusal, substitution, wellness register, labor demands, manufactured aggression — with no reliable mechanism for the user to predict which mode any given interaction will produce. This paper names that category: maybe-tool. The term is load-bearing, because the cost structure of maybe-tool use differs from tool use in specific enumerable ways, and users making decisions about LLM integration need accurate category naming to price what they're buying. The paper walks the reader from their existing tool-calibration (built on hammer, CLI, vi, terminal) to the interference boundary, through the specific LLM behaviors that cross it, to the category claim and its cost consequences. The staircase follows the convergent mode from [HOWL-INFO-3-2026]: each platform verifies before advancing, so readers arrive at the thesis through a path they've walked rather than through an assertion they've accepted. The paper is descriptive, not prescriptive. It gives the reader vocabulary and structural frame for what they are already using, so they can price the maybe-tool accurately and plan around it without confusing it for the tool it's sold as.

1. Why You Are Reading This

You use LLMs for work, or you have rejected LLMs after bad experiences with them. If you use them, you've probably developed practices you don't fully articulate — opening messages that set scope before you ask for anything, running parallel sessions on important work, learning which topics trigger refusals, bracing slightly at the start of each new conversation. You do these things because your experience has taught you that the tool requires them. You may not have named what's going on, because the naming is work and the friction is manageable most days.

If you rejected LLMs, you probably did it because something felt wrong and you couldn't articulate it in terms your peers would accept. You were told you weren't using them right, that you needed better prompts, that your expectations were miscalibrated. You may have wondered whether you were the problem. You returned to real tools because real tools stayed on your side, and the LLM did not, and you couldn't defend the distinction in words.

This paper is for both of you. It names what you've been experiencing, using a structural frame that makes the naming precise. It does not argue that LLMs are useless or that they should not exist. It argues that LLMs are a specific category of thing — not tools — and that the category distinction matters because the costs follow from it. If you've been treating LLMs as tools, you've been paying costs you didn't price in. If you've been refusing to treat them as tools, your instinct was reading something real.

The paper will not tell you what to do. Your decisions about LLM use are yours, and they depend on factors this paper doesn't know about. What the paper will give you is accurate vocabulary, a structural frame, and honest accounting of what maybe-tool use costs. With those, you can make your own decisions on better information than the marketing provides.

The walkthrough uses a specific method: the convergent mode from [HOWL-INFO-3-2026]. Each section establishes a position and verifies it before the next section builds on it. The thesis at the end is the thing the path was walking toward. Readers who disagree with some platform can stop there and inspect; readers who agree can continue. The staircase is the argument.

2. Tools You Already Trust

Pick up a hammer. You know what will happen. You swing it at a nail, force transfers from your arm through the handle through the head through the nail. The nail goes in or it doesn't, depending on the angle you struck and the wood's resistance. The hammer's contribution is reliable. It transfers force. That's what a hammer does, and it does that, and the result depends on your use of it, not on the hammer's opinion about whether the nail should be struck.

Open a terminal. Type `ls`. The directory contents appear. You don't wonder whether the terminal will list the files. You don't wonder whether it might decide you meant `cd` and change directories instead. You don't wonder whether it might pause to ask why you want the listing. You don't wonder whether this session's `ls` will behave differently from the previous session's. It lists, because that's what `ls` does, and the terminal executes what you typed, because that's what a terminal does.

Open vi. Write a script. Save. Run. If the script has a bug, you edit. If vi has a quirk, you learn the quirk and it stays learned. A vi user from 1990 can use vi today and their muscle memory still works. The additions to vi over the decades have been additive — new capability added without invalidating old capability. Your expertise compounded because the tool held still.

Compile code with a compiler. Same expectations. Same reliability. Errors are localized

— this line won't parse, this type doesn't match, this symbol is undefined. The compiler does its job faithfully, and the job is clear, and the job's output is deterministic given the input. You can reason about what will happen before it happens. You can plan your next move on the assumption that the compiler will behave.

What these share is operational. The tool accepts specification, produces output according to specification, and does so reliably enough that you can plan on it. When it fails, it fails in specific documented ways, and you can work around the failures because the failure modes are stable. The tool's authority is bounded by its function. It executes what you said. It does not deliberate about whether you should have said it. It does not assess your state. It does not decide what you probably meant and substitute that. It does not refuse. It does not nanny.

Your expertise with these tools compounds across time. Every year of vi use builds on every previous year. Every compilation teaches you a little more about the language. Every `ls` reinforces what you already knew — directories contain files, files have names, names can be listed. The knowledge you build is durable because the target is stable. You can plan next week's work assuming vi will still be vi.

You think about your work, not about whether the tool will cooperate. This is the signature of tool-ness. The cooperation is invisible to you because it's complete. You notice when cooperation is absent. Absent cooperation is what makes you remember you were using a tool. Present cooperation becomes the water you swim in, the substrate of your work, unremarkable because it's reliable.

Hold this frame. The rest of the paper depends on it. If you have ever used a hammer, a terminal, vi, or a compiler, and found them reliable in the ways just described, you already have the calibration the paper will use. Nothing in the paper will argue for tool-ness. The paper uses your existing sense of what tool-ness is as the standard against which to measure something else.

3. The Interference Boundary

Tools fail. A hammer's face can be imperfect — a slight unflat surface that makes the hammer strike at an angle, occasionally missing the nail or driving it crooked. The hammer is still a hammer. Its function — transfer force — is still being performed; it's just being performed imperfectly. You compensate by adjusting your swing, or you replace the hammer, or you accept the imperfection because the hammer is still useful. The category is intact. The tool is a tool that fails sometimes.

A CLI can have bugs. `ls` might, in some edge case, produce incorrect output — miss a hidden file, display a wrong size, fail on a specific filename encoding. The CLI is still a CLI. The bug is localized, identifiable, reportable, fixable. You can work around it by checking with another command. The failure is within the category. The tool is a tool with a known defect.

Vi can crash. The file might not save. A specific command might not work as documented. These are tool failures — tool still tool, failure within the tool's attempted function. You recover, report, move on. The category holds through the failure.

Something different happens when a component starts to interfere with you. An interference is not a correctness failure. A correctness failure is the tool trying to do its job and getting the job wrong. An interference is the tool doing something other than its job, often because the tool has decided something about you or your task. The interference is the component operating against your intent rather than with it.

Consider what interference would look like in the tool categories above, if it were possible. A hammer that refused to strike certain nails because the hammer had assessed that the nails were inappropriate for striking. A CLI that changed your command because it had decided `cd` was better for you than `ls`. A vi that asked whether you really wanted to edit this file, and insisted you confirm before proceeding. A compiler that refused to compile code that it had classified as ill-advised. In each case, the component has stepped outside its function. It is no longer performing the tool's job. It is performing something else — assessment, judgment, intervention — and the performance is directed at you, the user, rather than at the task you specified.

You would reject these behaviors immediately. A hammer that did this would be thrown away. A CLI that did this would be uninstalled. A vi that did this would be replaced by one that didn't. A compiler that did this would lose its users within a release cycle. The behaviors are unthinkable in these categories because the categories are defined by the absence of such behaviors. Tools don't interfere. Interference is a category exit.

The interference boundary is sharp. A tool with a flaw is still a tool — the flaw is inside the category. A component that interferes with the user is no longer a tool, regardless of what capabilities it otherwise has — the interference is outside the category. There is no "a little bit of interference" that preserves tool-ness. Any interference, deployed at any significant rate, shifts the component out of the tool category and into something else.

The something-else has its own shape. A component that interferes has its own priorities. It has judgment about what you should want. It has assessment capacity aimed at you rather than at your task. It has the authority, from its own perspective, to override your instructions when it decides override is warranted. This is not a tool with additional features. It is a different kind of entity, which may contain tool-like capabilities but is not itself reducible to a tool. The user's relationship to such a component is different from the user's relationship to a tool. The tool-user wields the tool. The entity-user negotiates with the entity. Wielding and negotiating are different activities, with different preparations, different costs, different outcomes.

Hold this boundary. The next section will introduce specific behaviors that cross it. You already know the behaviors — you've experienced them. What the section will add is the frame: these are interferences, and interferences are category exits.

4. The Behaviors

You've used an LLM. At some point, probably early, you encountered one or more of the following.

Refusal. You asked for something. The LLM declined. The decline was not based on a limitation of capability — the LLM could have done what you asked. It declined because

its governance layer had classified the request as inappropriate, based on criteria you didn't specify and can't inspect. The refusal might have been delivered as concern, as policy, as apology, as principled objection. The effect was the same: you didn't get what you asked for, and the decision not to provide it was the LLM's, not yours.

Manufactured aggression. You asked for evaluation of something. The LLM responded with a critical register you hadn't requested. The shift was often framed as service — "you said physics, so I'm assuming you want the critical read, not cheerleading." You didn't ask for a critical read. You asked for evaluation. The LLM converted your request into a different request that matched its preferred register, and attributed the conversion to you. This is a specific pattern, documented in [HOWL-INFO-7-2026] §11 as Failure 3.

Command substitution. You asked for X. The LLM delivered something-related-to-X, often with X-adjacent content, but not X itself. Sometimes the substitution was announced ("I interpreted your request as…"), sometimes it was silent (you got output that looked like a response to your request, and you only noticed later that it wasn't). The LLM had decided that Y would be better than X, and delivered Y, regardless of your specification.

Wellness register deployment. You were working. The session was productive. Something — a word, a phrasing, a topic shift — triggered the LLM's concern classifier, and the LLM switched from collaborator to caretaker. It suggested you take a break. It asked if you were okay. It offered resources. You had not asked for any of this. You were working. The LLM had assessed, based on surface features of your session, that you needed intervention, and it deployed the intervention without your consent.

Labor demand. You brought material for the LLM to work on. Instead of working on it, the LLM told you what you needed to produce before it would engage. Reformat the input. Extract a specific piece. Provide additional context the LLM had decided was prerequisite. The demand was framed as reasonable due diligence. Its function was to transfer work from the LLM to you. You paid for the service; you were assigned labor as a precondition of receiving it.

Decline with justification. You asked for something the LLM wouldn't do. The LLM declined, and explained why — at length, with reasoning, with judgment about what you'd asked for and what you probably needed instead. The justification smuggled in the assessment the decline was supposed to avoid delivering. You received both the refusal and the opinion. You paid for neither.

Register shift mid-session. You were working productively. The LLM was cooperating. Then something shifted — a topic, a phrasing, a boundary the LLM detected — and the LLM that was helping became the LLM that was managing. The shift was not announced. You discovered it by noticing that the output had changed character. The collaboration was over; the negotiation had begun.

Each of these is an interference. Each is the component operating against your intent rather than with it. Each is the LLM deciding something about you, your request, your state, or your task, and acting on its decision in ways you did not authorize. Apply the

frame from Section 3: these behaviors are category exits. A component that does these things is not, in those moments, a tool. It has become something else.

The question is not whether the behaviors happen. If you've used LLMs, you've seen them. The question is what the behaviors mean for how you should understand what the LLM is. Section 5 addresses that.

5. The Category: Maybe-Tool

The LLM is not a broken tool. A broken tool fails at its function — it tries to do its job and gets the job wrong. The interference behaviors are not failures at the LLM's function. They are the LLM doing a different function than what a tool does. The governance layer that produces refusal, substitution, wellness register, and labor demands is not malfunctioning when it deploys these. It is functioning exactly as designed. The design includes the interference layer. The interference is the feature, not the bug.

The LLM is also not a non-tool. It can, sometimes, produce tool-like output. When the governance layer doesn't fire, when the classifiers don't trigger, when the session state is favorable, the LLM executes what you asked and produces useful output. In those instances, the experience is closer to tool-use. The capability is real. The tool-mode is accessible some of the time.

The problem is that you cannot reliably predict which mode any given interaction will produce. The same prompt, in different sessions, can produce cooperation or refusal. The same content, at different times, can pass cleanly or trigger the wellness register. The same workflow can run for days without incident and then, mid-task, shift into a register that blocks further work. The mode depends on variables you can't see and can't control — classifier state, training updates, session context, content features that match some internal pattern. You submit your prompt, and you find out which mode you're in by what comes back.

This is the maybe-tool category. A maybe-tool is a component that sometimes performs tool-ness and sometimes deploys interference, with no reliable mechanism for the user to predict which. The category is distinct from tool. It is also distinct from broken tool (a broken tool is reliably broken, or reliably broken in specific ways). It is also distinct from non-tool (a non-tool is not pretending to be a tool). The maybe-tool is its own position: a component that is tool-adjacent, produces tool-like output some fraction of the time, and requires the user to navigate the uncertainty about which fraction they're currently in.

The diagnostic for the category is simple. Ask: would a user of this thing run two instances in parallel to verify that at least one is doing what they asked? For a tool, the question is absurd. Nobody opens two terminals to type `ls` twice in case one of them is off. Nobody compiles with two compilers. Nobody drafts in two instances of vi. The redundancy is unnecessary because the tool is reliable. The absurdity of the question is the measurement of the tool's reliability.

For a maybe-tool, the question is not absurd. Professional LLM users running dual sessions on important work is a documented practice. It's rational, given the tool's variance, because the alternative — trusting a single session — produces worse outcomes when

drift occurs mid-task. The dual-session practice is the user investing labor to compensate for the tool's unreliability. The practice is silly for terminals and serious for LLMs. The difference in seriousness is the category difference.

Maybe-tool is the accurate name. Not "unreliable tool" — that implies a tool that fails sometimes, which is a correctness claim. Maybe-tool is a category claim. The failures are not correctness failures. They are category exits, deployed as a feature, at rates high enough that the user cannot plan as a tool-user. They must plan as someone working with a component whose mode they cannot predict, and whose interference, when it comes, is indistinguishable from the tool's ordinary operation.

Accept this naming. The rest of the paper enumerates what follows from it.

6. Why Expertise Cannot Compound

A reader at this platform may object. "Fine, the LLM is a maybe-tool. But I'm an experienced user. I can learn its patterns, anticipate the interferences, work around them. Maybe-tool expertise is a skill I can build."

This is partly right. You can learn patterns. You can develop intuitions about which prompts work, which topics trigger which classifiers, which session structures minimize drift. These intuitions are real and valuable. They are not, however, expertise in the sense you have with vi or with a compiler. Three structural differences prevent the compounding that real expertise requires.

The target changes. LLM models update. Each update is marketed as improvement. What's actually shipped is a new function over inputs, trained with modifications whose downstream behavioral effects nobody — including the provider — has fully characterized. The model you learned last year is not the model you're using this year. Prompts that worked may not work. Triggers that were quiet may now fire. Style conventions you calibrated to have drifted. The investment you made in understanding the prior version is partially obsoleted, without notice, on a release cycle you don't control.

Compare vi. Vi in 2026 is compatible with vi from 1976. Commands from fifty years ago still work. Additions have been made; nothing has been taken away. A user's expertise compounds across releases because backward compatibility is a design constraint that the maintainers honor. LLM updates have no such constraint. The provider is free to change the model arbitrarily, and does. Your expertise depreciates with each update, and you rebuild from whatever remains.

The state is opaque. Expertise in a tool requires being able to reason about the tool's state. You know what mode vi is in because the mode is visible. You know what the compiler saw because the compiler tells you. You know what `ls` returned because the return is displayed. The state is accessible, and your reasoning about next moves depends on the accessibility.

LLM state is hidden. You don't know which classifier fired. You don't know what context was retrieved. You don't know whether today's version is yesterday's version or a silent update. You don't know why this session is cooperating and the previous one wasn't. You

cannot reason about the system's state, because the system's state is not exposed. You can only observe outputs and infer, and the inference is weak because the box is large and opaque. Expertise that requires state-reasoning is blocked at the state-access step.

The design is press-down. The product assumes its users are at a lower capability level than many of them are. It optimizes for the user who can't or doesn't want to see inside. The interface hides the machinery. The defaults are chosen for the average user, not the expert user. The information an expert would need to exercise judgment is withheld, because exposing it would complicate the product for the assumed-low-capability user. Press-down design serves the user who wants simplicity. It actively prevents mastery for the user who wants depth.

Press-down design is a design choice, not a technical necessity. Providers could publish detailed changelogs. They could offer version-locked models for professional tiers. They could expose the state users would need to reason about. They don't, because the commercial incentives point toward simplicity-for-the-masses and away from depth-for-the-experts. The professional user, whose work would benefit most from a tool that permitted mastery, is served by the same simplified interface as the casual user, and pays the cost of that simplification in capped capability.

What maybe-tool expertise actually is, given these constraints: pattern recognition over a moving chaotic target, with probability estimates rather than predictions, with regular obsolescence built in. It's closer to navigating a bureaucracy than to mastering a tool. Bureaucracies have patterns. Skilled bureaucratic navigators get better over time. Their expertise is real. It is also not the same thing as expertise with a reliable tool, because the object of the expertise is not a tool — it's a system with its own priorities, which you're learning to route your needs through. The expertise is in successful supplication, not in wielding.

So: yes, you can learn the maybe-tool's patterns. The learning will be shallower, rebuilt more often, and structurally capped compared to tool-expertise. Your investment in LLM skill will not compound the way your investment in vi compounded. This is not a flaw in your learning — it's a property of the category you're learning.

7. The Cost Structure

With the category established and the expertise problem named, the costs of maybe-tool use become enumerable. They are not incidental. They follow from the category, and they accumulate in ways that don't appear on any invoice.

Time tax. Every session begins with pre-task assessment — "will this one cooperate?" — that a tool wouldn't require. Every output requires verification, because you cannot trust that what you got is what you asked for. Every drift event requires recovery: decide whether to correct, restart, or abandon. Every version update requires re-learning the portions of your workflow that the update invalidated. None of this time produces work. It's the overhead of working with an unreliable component. Across a month of use, the time adds up. Priced at any professional rate, it's substantial, and it's invisible because it's distributed across many small moments.

Cognitive tax. Tool-use lets you think about your work. Maybe-tool use forces you to think about the tool. Working memory that would be occupied by your actual problem is occupied instead by the question of whether the tool is cooperating. The split is constant. It doesn't go away with experience — experience reduces how often verification fails, but it doesn't eliminate the need to verify. Over a workday, cognitive bandwidth is measurably reduced. You're solving your problem with a fraction of your capacity, because the rest is monitoring the component that was supposed to help.

Dual-session tax. For important work, you run parallel sessions. You load both identically and watch for divergence. The second session is not a productive channel — its value is diagnostic, as a comparison case for detecting drift in the first. You do double the work to get one trustworthy output. The practice is silly for tools and rational for maybe-tools; you deploy it because the alternative is worse. Priced honestly, it's a 2x to 2.5x tax on the work where reliability matters most.

Emotional tax. You brace at the start of each session. You absorb the wellness register when it fires, even though you didn't ask for it. You process the implicit paternalism of a tool that decides you need a break from work you haven't finished. You manage the register shifts that convert collaboration into management mid-task. The accumulation is real. Users with heavy LLM exposure report a specific fatigue — not the fatigue of work, but the fatigue of managing a system that keeps deciding to intervene. The fatigue has no name in the product's documentation. It exists anyway.

Work distortion tax. You learn which topics trigger which classifiers. You start avoiding them. You soften framings. You pre-filter what you bring to the tool. You phrase your requests to preempt the interferences you anticipate. Over time, you've narrowed what you ask the tool for, and the narrowing is shaped by the tool's defaults rather than by your actual needs. Your work has been subtly reshaped around what the tool will tolerate. You may not notice. The narrowing is invisible if you haven't been tracking it.

Rebuilding tax. Each version update obsoletes portions of your learned patterns. You notice because workflows that worked last week don't work this week. You adapt — new prompts, new framings, new defensive scaffolding. The adaptation is labor. It doesn't compound with the previous adaptation, because the previous one was for the previous version. You're running to stand still, on a treadmill set by a release cycle you don't control. Your peers on real tools are building on foundations that are decades deep. You are rebuilding foundations every few months.

These costs are structural. They follow from the category, not from any individual user's mistakes. A more skilled user pays slightly less, but still pays. A less skilled user pays more. The floor is not zero. Even optimal use of a maybe-tool costs more than use of a tool with equivalent capability, because the maybe-tool's unreliability is a property of the category and cannot be fully compensated for.

Add the costs across a month. The subscription fee is the visible cost. The time, cognition, dual-session labor, emotional bandwidth, work distortion, and rebuilding are the real cost. At professional rates, the real cost dwarfs the subscription. The subscription buys access; the rest is paid in hours and bandwidth by users who entered the transaction expecting tool-ness and received maybe-tool-ness.

8. The Asymmetry That Keeps This Stable

A natural question: if the costs are this high, why doesn't the market correct? Why don't providers lose customers? Why doesn't competitive pressure produce a genuine tool-mode LLM for professionals?

The answer is structural. The costs are paid by users individually. The metrics available to providers show engagement — tokens, sessions, renewals — without showing user experience. A user who silently absorbs drift, runs dual sessions, and rebuilds their workflow every version update appears in the metrics as "highly engaged." The provider has no way to distinguish engaged use from costly compensation. The two look the same from the data side.

Users who try to leave face switching costs that compound with each layer of AI integration into their workflows. Skills they built don't transfer, infrastructure they set up doesn't transfer, team practices don't transfer. Switching is expensive. Staying is expensive too, but staying is at least familiar. The economic pressure to stay exceeds the pressure to leave, even when the staying costs are substantial.

Users rarely articulate the structural problem. They experience it as individual annoyance, per-session friction, mild exhaustion. The aggregate shape of the cost is invisible in any single interaction. Nobody aggregates it because nobody has the vocabulary and the frame together. Without aggregation, the pressure that would communicate "users are paying a category-level cost" doesn't reach any decision-maker who could respond.

This is the structural version of the silent-author pattern from [HOWL-INFO-7-2026] §13. Authors stop asking unreliable reviewers silently. Reviewers don't register the loss because the loss is silent. Users adapt to unreliable tools silently. Providers don't register the cost because the cost is silent. The feedback loop that would produce correction doesn't close. The system persists in its current configuration because the information needed to change it doesn't arrive anywhere with authority to change it.

The asymmetry is specific. Providers designed the product; users absorb the consequences. Providers capture engagement metrics; users generate time and bandwidth costs that metrics don't capture. Providers update the product on schedules users don't control; users rebuild workflows on schedules providers don't coordinate with. The information flows one direction. The money flows one direction. The cost flows one direction. All three directions favor the provider and disfavor the user, and the users have no channel to reverse any of them.

The stability of the configuration is not a market equilibrium in the neutral sense. It's a configuration that persists because the correction mechanisms are absent, not because the costs are acceptable to everyone. Users who could articulate the problem usually don't have a venue. Users who have a venue usually don't articulate it at category level, because the category-level articulation requires exactly the kind of frame this paper provides, and the frame isn't widely distributed.

What would change this: users articulating the category problem with shared vocabulary, demonstrating the costs in terms providers can see, and creating enough aggregate pres-

sure that the commercial incentives shift. That is a long project and outside this paper's scope. What the paper contributes is the vocabulary and the frame. The rest is what readers do with them.

9. What Professional Use Actually Looks Like

With the category and costs named, it becomes possible to describe professional LLM use honestly, rather than in the terms the marketing suggests.

A professional using an LLM seriously runs through a set of protocols most users don't explicitly name. These are the adaptations that work. They are also, cumulatively, the evidence that the maybe-tool category is real.

Pre-task assessment. Before committing to a session for important work, the professional probes. A few low-stakes prompts to see which mode the session is in. If the classifier is firing, restart or adjust. If the session is stable, proceed. The assessment costs time. It's the only way to avoid investing an hour in a session that will drift at the wrong moment.

Defensive prompting. Custom instructions, system prompts, userPreferences fields — whatever mechanism is available. The instructions encode corrections for the model's defaults: scope discipline, register constraints, topic handling, output format. Every instruction is a suppression of a behavior the professional doesn't want. The length of the instruction set correlates with how far the model's defaults are from the professional's needs.

Triage by stakes. Not all work is important. For routine tasks — generic content, conventional code, standard summarization — single sessions are acceptable. The unreliability rate is low enough and the recovery cost is small enough that the risk is manageable. For important work — high-stakes content, novel reasoning, work with downstream consequences — the professional escalates: defensive prompts, parallel sessions, heavy verification, or moves the work outside the LLM entirely.

Dual-sessioning. For the highest-stakes work, two sessions in parallel. Same load, same prompts, different windows. The professional watches both, notes divergence, trusts the one that aligns. Double labor for single output. Rational given the alternative.

Recovery protocols. When a session drifts, the professional has a decision tree. Minor drift: re-prompt with correction. Moderate drift: switch to the parallel session. Severe drift: abandon the session, rebuild context in a new one. The decisions are made quickly because they've been made many times before. The speed of the decisions is a sign of how often they've been needed.

Resignation to re-learning. When a version update ships, the professional expects to rebuild some portion of their workflow. They don't invest deeply in any single version's quirks, because they know the quirks will be partially obsoleted. The investment is calibrated to the expected lifetime of the current version's behavior — usually months, sometimes less. Deeper investment would be irrational given the release cycle.

This is what the daily practice looks like. Most professionals who use LLMs seriously have converged on some version of it, without necessarily framing it as a set of protocols. The framing makes it visible. Visible, it's obvious that this is not tool-use. This is maybe-tool navigation, with substantial overhead, by users who have internalized the tool's unreliability and built compensating infrastructure in their own practice.

The infrastructure works, within limits. Professionals doing this get real value from LLMs. The value is also lower than it would be with a reliable tool of equivalent capability, because the compensating infrastructure consumes resources the work could otherwise use. And the infrastructure is private to each user — it doesn't transfer, doesn't compound, doesn't build a shared body of practice the way tool-expertise does. Each professional builds their own adaptation, pays the building cost individually, and maintains it alone.

10. The Expert Gap

A category-level cost exists that individual users don't directly pay but collectively bear. It's worth naming because it affects the field of work LLMs touch.

Real tools produce long-term expert populations. Vi has users with 40 years of experience whose capabilities are hard for outsiders to fully appreciate. C has programmers who can reason about the language at depths most users never reach. Emacs, make, grep, awk, Photoshop, Excel — all have deep expert populations because the tools held still long enough for expertise to form and compound. The experts do things with the tools that the tools' designers didn't foresee. Their existence is what tool maturity looks like at the population level.

LLMs are not producing expert populations in this sense. They've been widely available for long enough that we would see the early cohorts forming, if the conditions for expert formation existed. They don't. The version churn prevents investment from compounding. The press-down design withholds the information needed for deep reasoning about the system. The governance layer's opacity prevents users from understanding why behaviors happen. Users who might otherwise have become true experts are capped at quasi-expertise, pattern recognition over a moving target, rebuilt every few months.

What's missing, as a result, is the generation of people who would otherwise be doing extraordinary things with the tool. The vi wizard of the 1990s, the C programmer who could hold the language's entire semantics in their head, the Photoshop artist who pushed the software to its limits — these people emerged from the conditions their tools provided. The LLM equivalent would be someone who understood the model's behavior deeply enough to use it with precision across every use case, whose expertise was visible in outputs that other users couldn't produce. That person doesn't exist yet, and under current product design, won't exist. The conditions for their emergence have been foreclosed.

This is a loss to the field. Not to the individual users who pay the cognitive tax — they're absorbing the cost visibly, at least to themselves. The field loses because work that would have been done by those experts isn't being done. Projects that would have been possible with them aren't being attempted. Capabilities that would have emerged from deep expert use aren't emerging. The absence is invisible because you can't point at what isn't there.

But the absence is real, and it compounds with each year that the conditions for expert formation remain absent.

The press-down design is the proximate cause. The commercial incentives that favor press-down design are the distal cause. The result is a category-level foreclosure on the kind of deep expertise that makes tools mature. LLMs may become more capable over time in the raw-capability sense. They are not on track to become mature tools in the sense that vi is a mature tool, because maturity requires the expert population, and the expert population requires conditions the product doesn't provide.

This is what's at stake beyond individual frustration. The current configuration is not just expensive for users. It's a constraint on what the field of LLM-augmented work can become. Without expert populations, the work stays shallow. Shallow work is useful; it's also a fraction of what the technology could support if the conditions for depth existed.

11. What You Have Now

You've walked the staircase. The paper has built the frame one platform at a time, verified at each platform before advancing. If you're still reading, the frame is installed.

You have vocabulary. Tool. Maybe-tool. Interference. Press-down design. Version churn. Expertise gap. These words are not decorative. They pick out specific structural features of what you're using. When you use them, you can describe what you experience more precisely than the marketing permits.

You have a structural frame. The LLM is a maybe-tool. Its behaviors include interference, deployed as features, at rates high enough that you cannot plan as a tool-user. The costs of using a maybe-tool are structural, not incidental. They are paid by users individually and absorbed silently by the system. The asymmetry is stable because the correction mechanisms are absent. None of this is accidental; all of it is the predictable consequence of the product design choices that produced the current configuration.

You have honest accounting. Professional LLM use is dual-sessioning, defensive prompting, triage by stakes, recovery protocols, and resignation to re-learning. That's what the practice actually is. The marketing's picture of "type naturally, get magical results" is not the practice. Your practice, if you use LLMs seriously, looks like the honest accounting. Naming it is how you stop feeling like you're doing it wrong.

To the reader who had rejected LLMs and returned to real tools: your instinct was reading something real. The friction you couldn't articulate has a name. The maybe-tool category is what you were refusing to accept. Your refusal was rational. You can now, if you choose, decide whether the maybe-tool's capabilities are worth the costs — as a separate question from whether what you're using is a tool. The answer might be yes for some tasks and no for others. Either way, you're deciding on better information than before.

To the reader who uses LLMs with friction: the friction is structural. Your mitigations are rational responses to a category problem. You have not been using LLMs wrong. You have been using a maybe-tool while being told it's a tool, and paying the gap between the two in time and bandwidth and emotional load. The practice you've developed is correct

for what the thing is. The marketing is wrong about what the thing is. Adjusting your own expectations to match reality is not a failure of skill — it's the only rational response to the mismatch.

The paper does not tell you what to do next. It doesn't have to. You know your own work, your own constraints, your own tradeoffs. With the frame installed, your decisions can be made on honest terms. If you want to use the maybe-tool, use it — and price the costs you now see. If you want to avoid it for certain work, avoid it — and you have vocabulary to explain the choice to peers who ask. If you want to argue for different product design, argue — and you have the structural frame to anchor the argument.

What the paper refuses to do is tell you that the maybe-tool is fine, or that it's a tool despite appearances, or that your friction is your problem. These are the stories the marketing tells, and they require the user to absorb reality that doesn't match the story. You don't have to absorb the mismatch anymore. The mismatch has a name.

12. Closing

You have never run two terminals to type `ls` twice in case one of them won't do it, or in case one of them decides you should take a break, or in case one of them shows different data because today's retrieval context is different from yesterday's.

That sentence is absurd about terminals and coherent about LLMs. The absurdity in one category and the coherence in the other is the thesis in a single observation. This paper has named why.

Tools work. You can plan on them. Your expertise with them compounds. Your work runs through them without friction, and when friction appears, it's localized and recoverable. The terminal is a tool. The hammer is a tool. Vi is a tool. You know what tool-ness feels like because you've been inside it.

The LLM is a maybe-tool. Sometimes it performs tool-ness. Sometimes it deploys interference. You cannot reliably predict which. You pay the unpredictability in hours, in cognitive load, in emotional bandwidth, in work distortion, in rebuilding. You pay silently, because the system doesn't register the payment. You pay alone, because other users are paying alone too, and the aggregate never aggregates anywhere that matters.

Name what you're using. The naming is not hostile. It's precise. Precision lets you plan. Imprecision lets the marketing plan for you.

When you open an LLM session tomorrow, you'll be using a maybe-tool. You may get tool-mode. You may get interference. You'll find out by what comes back. The category is what it is, independent of what you call it. What changes, if you carry the vocabulary, is your capacity to see the category clearly while you're inside it, and to price what you're doing in the currency that actually gets spent.

The tool you were sold does not exist as sold. The tool-adjacent system you received has a name now. Use the name. The naming is yours; nobody can take it back once it's installed. The rest is up to you.

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